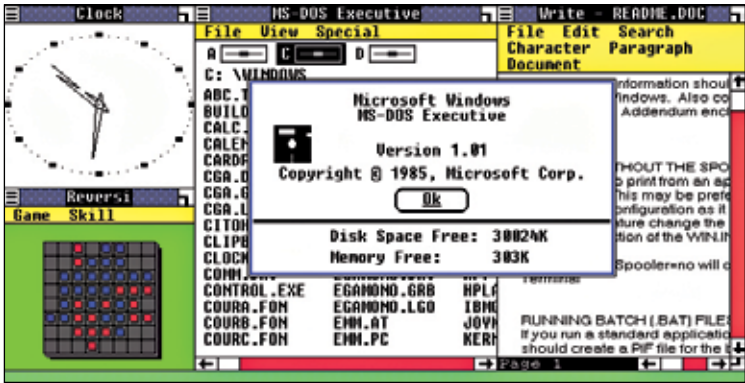




The very first version of Windows

was a 16-bit operating system and came out back in 1985 – a time when you really had to work hard to fill up 100kB of space.

Windows 2.0 came and went uneventfully, and then came the very popular Windows 3.0 in 1990. In 1992 a minor update, Windows 3.1, was released. This is also, however, a time when things started to get interesting. Windows was just at v3.0 but already there was a completely redesigned version of Windows in the works, Windows NT. Windows NT 3.1 quickly followed Windows 3.1 in 1993, and unlike Windows 3.1, Windows NT 3.1 was 32-bit not 16-bit. Windows NT introduced the Win32 API, which was used in Windows 95 as well and continues on to this day – with significant improvements of course. Windows NT was also written with multiple different architectures in mind, although it didn't stray far from x86.

It was supposed to be the new base for future versions of Windows, but unfortunately this was not to be. Windows 95 got built on Windows 3.1 instead, and so was Windows 98, and – the one that should not be named, but we still will – Windows ME. Meanwhile a line of Windows versions based on Windows NT continued, with Windows NT 4, and then Windows 2000 (which is essentially Windows NT 5).

Windows XP finally merged the old Windows 3.1, 95, 98 series of Windows with the NT series. Windows XP was mostly just a re-skinned Windows 2000, and was technically Windows NT 5.1. It was also the first version of Windows to support the full capabilities of 64-bit processors in a special Windows XP Professional 64-bit edition, which unlike the 32-bit version of Windows XP, was based on Windows Server 2003 rather than Windows 2000 (making it v5.2).